contain several regulatory proteins like **tropomyosin** and **troponin** which help in regulating the contraction of muscles along with **actin** and **myosin**.

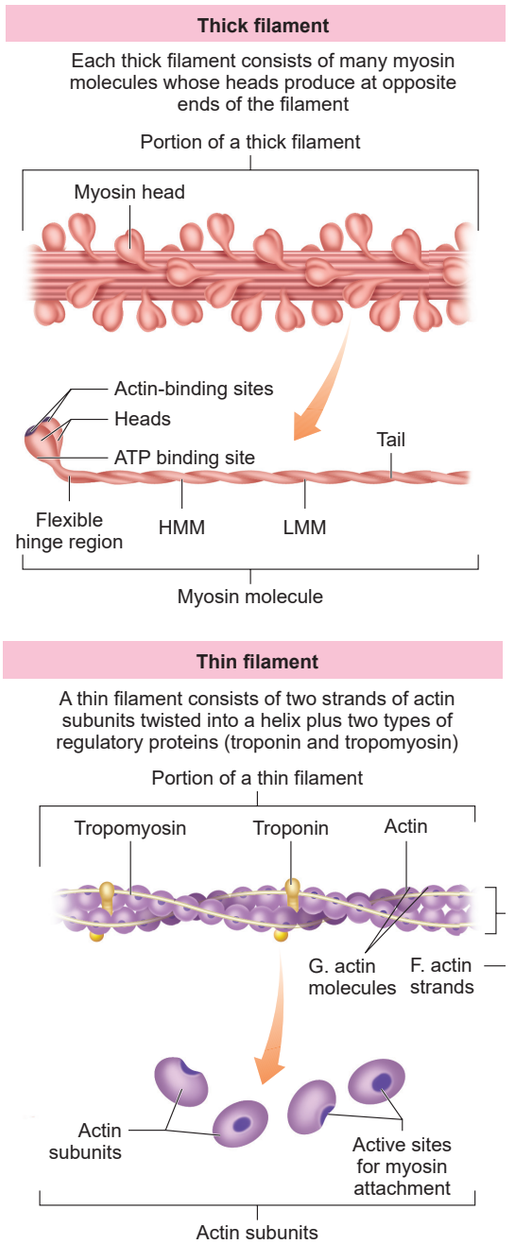


Figure 9. 2 Composition of thick and thin filaments

9.5 Mechanism of muscle contraction

Sliding filament theory: In 1954, Andrew F. Huxley and Rolf Niedergerke proposed the sliding-filament theory to explain muscle contraction. According to this theory, overlapping actin and myosin filaments of fixed length slide past one another in an energy requiring process, resulting in muscle contraction. The contraction of muscle fibre is a remarkable process that helps in creating a force to move or to resist a load. The force which is created by the contracting muscle is called muscle tension. The load is a weight or force that opposes contraction of a muscle. Contraction is the creation of tension in the muscle which is an active process and relaxation is the release of tension created by contraction. Muscle contraction is initiated by a nerve impulse sent by the central nervous system (CNS) through a motor neuron. The junction between the motor neuron and the sarcolemma of the muscle fibre is called the neuromuscular junction or motor end plate. When nerve impulse reaches a neuromuscular junction, acetylcholine is released. It initiates the opening of multiple gated channels in sarcolemma. The action potential travels along the T-tubules and triggers the release of calcium ions from the sarcoplasmic reticulum. The released calcium ions bind to troponin on thin filaments. The tropomyosin uncovers the myosin-binding sites on thin filaments. Now the active sites are exposed to the heads of myosin to form a cross-bridge (Figure 9.3). During cross-bridge formation actin and myosin form a protein complex called actomyosin. Utilizing the energy released from hydrolysis of ATP, the myosin head rotates until it forms a 90° angle with the long axis of the filament. In this position myosin binds to an actin and activates a contraction – relaxation cycle which is followed by a power stroke.

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